ABOVE AVERAGE WIN FOR BHAJAN LAL

The CM meets the qualified success in urban body polls with jubilation and relief—it's a veto for naysayers and saboteurs

Even those bald numbers don't fully reveal how competitive it was. At 34.24 per cent, the Congress was only a photo finish behind the BJP's 35.18 per cent in vote share. The ruling party managed a clear majority in four of 10 corporations; four were hung, leaving Independents as kingmakers. In Bharatpur, CM Bhajan Lal Sharma's home town, the latter practically swept the poll, embarrassing both BJP and Congress.

It was feared that voters could show a thumbs-down to Sharma and his crew of relative novices. Also, speculation on internal sabotage aimed at forcing New Delhi to go for perestroika. None of that came about—at least not yet.



Takeaways

- **Results for Lal are just slightly better than expected, with BJP winning 4,179 wards**
- **Cong. gets 3,613, less than a % point behind in vote share**
- **Independent kingmakers, resort politics heighten drama**



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MODEST MOMENTUM

In 2019-20, going into that poll cycle as the ruling party, the Congress had taken 123 of 196 civic bodies. This result trims that. But a comparison with 2014-15 is more revealing. Then, the BJP secured 46.49 per cent of the vote against Congress's 30.73 per cent, riding the momentum of Vasundhara Raje's 2013 assembly poll triumph and the Narendra Modi wave in the general election. The BJP is nowhere near that level of dominance today. Superimposed on assembly segments, the picture is even more sobering: the BJP would translate its current support into only about 20 of 50-odd seats. It had won 35 of these constituencies in 2023. Many BJP strongholds saw close contests. In Jaipur district, the Congress won 56 fewer wards but polled 886 more votes. The BJP retained Jaipur Municipal Corporation for a seventh time, polling 13,135 fewer votes but winning 25 more wards. Congress swept Bikaner, Union minister Arjun Meghwal's backyard.

The drama was worthy of an assembly poll. Both sides anticipated that defections could be decisive. An estimated 21,000 candidates were moved to resorts and hotels. The results have extended the stay for many. The resources being spent on the brazen horse-trading, which has already begun, contrasts with the condition of urban centres in Rajasthan, with potholed roads, dumps of garbage, overflowing sewage, waterlogged roads and traffic jams. Sharma is jubilant, though. He led from the front and came out unscathed. But the next test looms close: panchayat elections, ahead of his three-year milestone in December. ■